
Picture Credit: Nudes

Lokapriya Gopinath Bardoloi International Airport


Picture Credit: Nudes

Nuru Karim's biophilic design


Picture Credit: Nudes

Forest School, Pune

gave this intuition structure and discipline. Studying architecture and urbanism grounded his thinking in systems design and sustainability, teaching him to see buildings as part of larger social, climatic and infrastructural networks.

Yet professional practice forced him to unlearn the idea of certainty. Real projects rarely offer singular answers. They demand negotiation, adaptability and constant questioning. Over time, Karim learned to let design emerge from constraints and context rather than relying on predefined formulas or stylistic comfort.

This openness explains why his work moves seamlessly across scales, from private homes and hospitality projects to cultural institutions and large public infrastructure. What keeps him curious is not typology, but the opportunity to challenge inherited models.

In the context of India's rapid urbanisation, this impulse becomes critical. Karim believes architecture must move beyond replication toward innovation and that India should be seen not as a follower of global trends, but as a potential generator of new paradigms. His practice is driven by the belief that research-led, thoughtful design can position Indian architecture as a contributor to global discourse rather than a response to it.

Across regions and cultures, a quiet instinct runs consistently through Karim's work: the need to listen before drawing. The land does not reveal its answers all at once. It speaks gradually through climate, craft traditions, labour patterns, belief systems and invisible flows of people and energy. Architecture, in this view, is not an object imposed on a site, but a system in dialogue with its surroundings, expected to work hard, age with dignity and support both ecological and human systems.

That philosophy is particularly visible in Guwahati. From the outset, the terminal was imagined not just as a gateway to the world, but as a doorway into the North-East. Airports are often anonymous and interchangeable, yet here the ambition was to ensure that the first encounter with the region felt unmistakably rooted in its geography and culture. Efficiency was non-negotiable.

**At LGBIA, developed as part of a new generation of terminals under Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), Nuru Karim's ideas come together with unusual clarity.**

Circulation, capacity and operational clarity had to perform flawlessly. Yet Karim and his team kept returning to a deeper question: should an airport be measured only by how efficiently it moves people, or also by the memories it leaves behind?

The answer lies in the terminal's use of bamboo, a material deeply embedded in the everyday life of the North-East. For Karim, working with bamboo was never about nostalgia or symbolism. It was about understanding how the material behaves, its strength, lightness, renewability and modular intelligence and allowing those qualities to shape space, light and movement. By scaling it up and choreographing it spatially, bamboo becomes structure rather than ornament, collaborating with tradition rather than quoting it.

Karim's global experience reinforces this sensitivity. In places like Malawi, the landlocked African nation known for its vast lake systems and rural landscapes, design begins with humility, with listening to climate, soil, vegetation and light before form takes shape.

Constraints become sources of intelligence rather than limitations. In contrast, the Middle East demands clarity and discipline in the face of scale, speed and ambition, teaching him the importance of robust systems that can adapt over time without losing sensitivity.

Looking ahead, Karim sees airports evolving into living ecosystems rather than static terminals. Responsive materials, clean energy generation and AI-managed flows will create environments that adjust seamlessly to human needs.

Yet for him, the future of infrastructure is not only technological. It is deeply human. Sustainability, he believes, should function as invisible infrastructure, enhancing everyday experience through ecology that cools, filters and restores calm at scale.

India, with its urgency, diversity and pace of change, excites him most. Across its varied geographies lies a reservoir of indigenous knowledge waiting to be reinterpreted through contemporary tools. At Guwahati airport, that future already feels tangible, a place where ambition meets restraint, efficiency meets emotion and architecture listens before it speaks.